

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN JORDAN

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the water, land, and future of Jordan — and here, distinctively, almost everything turns on water, because Jordan is one of the most water-scarce countries on earth, and the destructive projects that most threaten its future are those that mine, waste, or gamble with a resource it cannot replace. Jordan has less renewable fresh water per person than almost any nation in the world, far below the threshold of absolute scarcity; Jordan has less renewable fresh water per person than almost any other nation in the entire world, far below even the recognised threshold of absolute water scarcity; most of its people receive piped water only a few hours a week; and its water crisis deepens with every year of population growth, refugee influx, and drought. Most of its people receive piped running water only a few hours in a given week; and its water crisis deepens with every passing year of population growth, refugee influx, and worsening drought. In this reality, the projects that do the gravest harm are not smoke-belching factories but water projects gone wrong: the mining of the ancient, non-renewable Disi aquifer, thirty thousand years old and shared with a neighbour some thirty thousand years old and shared with a neighbouring state, pumped for a few decades of relief at the cost of an irreplaceable store; the over-pumping that killed the Azraq wetlands a generation ago; the diversion and mineral extraction that are draining the Dead Sea by a metre a year and pockmarking its shore with sinkholes that swallow roads and homes; and the vast, costly, risky water mega-projects launched in desperation. This guide will be honest that Jordan faces a genuine and desperate water crisis with few good options, that the state pursues even the mining of fossil water not from carelessness but from need, that much of the harm is transboundary and beyond Jordan's sole control, and that the political space to oppose is limited in a kingdom with real red lines; but it will show that the levers here — the water-security argument that is the state's own paramount concern, the state's own water strategy and technical institutions, the undeniable science of depletion, the alternatives of efficiency and reuse, and the international support — are real, and can be used, carefully, within the system.

The Jordanian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Jordanian, and it is what gives this guide its real force. **Because water is Jordan's binding constraint and its foremost national-security concern, a project that mines, wastes, or gambles with water is self-defeating on the state's own terms, and can be opposed through the water-security argument, the state's own strategy and institutions, the science of depletion, and the alternatives of efficiency and reuse.** That combination — the water-security argument, the state's own strategy, the science of depletion, and the alternatives — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in the world's most water-scarce country, the case against a water-destroying project is a case the state itself, on its own deepest priority, cannot easily dismiss.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **Jordan's water crisis is real and desperate, its options are few, much harm is transboundary, and political space is limited.** The state mines fossil water and builds costly desalination not from indifference but because it is running out of water and has few alternatives, so opposition must reckon honestly with that desperation and offer real alternatives, not mere refusal; the Dead Sea's decline is driven largely by

diversion and extraction across borders, beyond Jordan's sole power to reverse; and Jordan is a monarchy with limited political space, where opposition works through technical, institutional, and civil-society channels rather than open confrontation, and with care. This guide does not pretend the water crisis is easily solved, or that the state has good options it is ignoring, or that opposition is free. What it shows is how, through the water-security argument, the state's own strategy and institutions, the science of depletion, the alternatives, and the international support, communities can press for the wiser use and protection of Jordan's water — carefully, within the system, and with honest regard for a genuine crisis.

Most people who care about Jordan's water do not know HOW to use the levers a water-scarce kingdom offers. They watch the fossil aquifer drawn down, the wetlands gone, the Dead Sea shrinking, the sinkholes spreading — and either accept it as the unavoidable price of a thirsty nation, or protest without the water-security argument and the science behind them, which in a kingdom is constrained, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the state's own paramount concern for water, its own strategy and institutions, the undeniable science, the alternatives of efficiency and reuse. The gap between water protected and water squandered is here often a gap of method — the method of using the water-security argument, the state's own strategy, the science of depletion, and the alternatives together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Jordanian reality as it is, which is a water-scarce constitutional monarchy facing an existential water crisis with few good options. It is written for the person — in a water-stressed community, in Jordan's technical and civil-society world, or among its international partners — who sees the water mined and wasted and wants to know what can be done in a kingdom where water is the paramount concern but political space is limited. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the water-security argument, the state's own strategy and institutions, the science of depletion, the alternatives, and the international support — with the honest qualifiers that the crisis is desperate, the options are few, much harm is transboundary, and political space is limited, so the work is careful, within-system advocacy for the wiser use and protection of water, not open confrontation. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Jordanian case is particular. It is for the person — a water scientist or engineer, a member of a water-stressed community, someone in Jordan's environmental civil society, or an international water partner — willing to do the patient, careful, within-system work of pressing the state on its own paramount concern for water, rather than the open confrontation that a kingdom with red lines makes both ineffective and risky. That is not a lesser form of action but, in Jordan's conditions, the effective and responsible one, because here the levers that genuinely deliver are the water-security argument, the state's own strategy and trusted science, and the alternatives of efficiency and reuse, all of which are reached through the system rather than against it. Anyone tempted toward open confrontation should weigh both its ineffectiveness in a state that controls the arenas and its real risks to those who attempt it, and understand that the reachable, survivable, and often more effective path runs through the state's own obsession with water. This guide is an honest map of that within-system path — the path of protecting Jordan's water by pressing the state on the very concern it prizes above all.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a water-scarce kingdom where the work runs through the system:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the project, the water harm, and the alternative)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence -- the science of water)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the community and the technical coalition)

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & WATER-GOVERNANCE (the strategy, the science, the alternatives)
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STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it a water-security cause)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The scientific evidence feeds the water-security argument, the state's strategy, and the alternatives at once; the community and the technical experts organise within the system's limits; a submission to the water ministry, a scientific case, or an efficiency alternative is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of protecting Jordan's water.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Jordan's — an existential water scarcity and a state whose foremost concern is water — give a distinctive set:

- **The water-security argument.** In the world's most water-scarce country, **a project that mines, wastes, or gambles with water is self-defeating on the state's own terms** — the distinctive lever.
- **The state's own strategy and institutions.** Jordan's **water strategy and technical institutions** are a real standard and channel the state can be held to.
- **The science of depletion.** The **undeniable science** — the finite fossil aquifer, the dying Dead Sea, the lost wetlands — grounds the case.
- **The alternatives.** Because refusal alone fails, **efficiency, reuse, and demand management** offer the water a project would waste or mine.
- **The international support.** The **international water-security and donor apparatus** supports sustainable water in an aid-dependent kingdom.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that Jordan has good options it ignores. The crisis is **real and desperate**; the options are **few**; much harm is **transboundary**; and political space is **limited**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it offers alternatives, not mere refusal — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the water-security argument, the state's own strategy, the science of depletion, the alternatives, and the international support — to press for the wiser use and protection of water, honestly acknowledging the desperation of the crisis, the scarcity of options, the transboundary limits, and the constraints of political space.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that in a water-scarce kingdom, the levers run through the state's own foremost concern, which is water. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the water-security argument, the state's own strategy, the science of depletion, and the alternatives apply, because in Jordan a destructive project is met not by open confrontation, which is constrained, but by showing that it harms the water security the state prizes above all, marshalling the science, invoking the state's own strategy, and offering the alternatives.

The Levels of Decision

A Jordanian project runs through levels where water is the paramount concern.

The state and its water authority. The **state, the water ministry, and the water authority** drive and decide the water projects, and are the authority to be persuaded — on their own paramount concern, water security — rather than confronted.

The water strategy and the law. The **national water strategy and the water and environmental law** are the state's own standards, and a real channel, since holding the state to its own water priorities is the surest path.

The technical and scientific institutions. The **water scientists, engineers, and technical institutions**, whose expertise the state relies on, document the harm and the alternatives credibly and relatively safely.

Civil society and community. The **water-stressed communities, the environmental groups, and the civil society** can act within the system's limits to document and advocate.

The international partners. The **international water, donor, and development bodies** support sustainable water and can press an aid-dependent state.

The Journey of a Project

A Jordanian project — a well field in the fossil aquifer, a diversion, a mega-canal, a thirsty development — moves from a state plan driven by water need, through the water strategy and the assessment, toward the built project or the protected resource, with the **water-security argument, the science, the state's strategy, and the alternatives** able to intervene. **The water-security argument and the science are where the project is best met, and the state's strategy and the alternatives are what move the state** — and using them together, within the system, is the distinctive Jordanian approach. The distinctive levers are the **water-security argument**, the **state's strategy**, the **science of depletion**, and the **alternatives**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what water it mines, wastes, or endangers, how it harms the water security the state prizes, and how the science, the strategy, and the alternatives can be brought to bear**, because those are where a project can genuinely be met.

Follow the Project, the Water, and the Future

Behind a project stand the state, its water need, and the resource at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, what water is harmed, and — importantly here — **how it harms the nation's water security, what the state's own strategy says, what the science shows about depletion, and what alternative could serve the need with less harm**. Two questions unlock most Jordanian efforts: **What water is harmed, and how does it threaten the water security the state prizes?** and **Which lever — the argument, the strategy, the science, the alternatives — can meet it, within the system?** The water-security argument, the science, and the state's strategy are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Jordanian effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the water harm with the state's own trusted science; the within-system coalition exists to press that science through the state's own strategy and institutions; and the media, largely technical and international, exists to raise the stakes by connecting the harm to the nation's water security. Keep the water-security argument, the science, and the state's strategy at the centre of every submission, proposal, and publication, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single well field or diversion to the survival of a thirsty nation, and that grounds the whole struggle in the water security, the science, and the strategy the state itself professes as its foremost concern.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the levers — and in a water-scarce kingdom they centre on water. The **state, the water ministry, and the water authority**; the **water strategy and the law**; the **technical and scientific institutions**; the **water-stressed communities and civil society**; and the **international water and donor bodies**. In Jordan, the **water-security argument, the state's strategy, the science of depletion, and the alternatives** are the most distinctive levers, and they run through the state's own paramount concern. Each is a separate front, and a project shown by science to mine, waste, or endanger the water the state prizes above all, against its own strategy, and where alternatives exist, can genuinely be pressed — through the water authority, the science, and the alternatives — though, honestly, the crisis is desperate, the options are few, much harm is transboundary, and political space is limited, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working carefully within the system.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that Jordan's water crisis is desperate, its options few, much harm transboundary, and political space limited, even as the water-security argument, the state's strategy, and the science give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how water conflicts tend to go in Jordan and comparable water-scarce states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the harm can be **shown to threaten the water security the state prizes**, whether it can be **pressed through the state's own strategy and science**, and whether **real alternatives** can be offered. Where the water-security case is strong and alternatives exist, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the crisis is desperate, options are few, and the state has genuine need.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Water-security argument	40–60%	months–years	low	The self-defeating harm shown
Scientific case (depletion)	40–60%	months	low	Depletion and loss proven
State-strategy channel	35–55%	months–years	low	The state's own water priorities invoked
Efficiency / reuse alternatives	40–60%	months–years	moderate	The water served with less harm
Demand-management reform	30–50%	years	low–moderate	Waste and over-use curbed
International & donor support	40–60%	months–years	low	Sustainable water backed
All levers together	35–55%	months–years	moderate	Water protected; wiser use won

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Jordan's real strengths are its water priority and its science: the **water-security argument**, the **science of depletion**, the **state's strategy**, and the **alternatives**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the crisis is **desperate**, options are **few**, much harm is **transboundary**, and political space is **limited** — so progress comes through the water-security argument,

*A note on cost and risk: some levers here — the water-security argument, the scientific case, a submission to the water authority — cost mainly organisation and knowledge, and much science is already gathered by the state's own institutions and international partners. The alternatives — efficiency, reuse, demand management — need real resources, which the donors can supply. The scarce resources are **the technical and scientific capacity, the international support, and the careful navigation of the system** — much of it reachable through Jordan's water institutions and its donors. This shapes where a Jordanian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are access to the state's own water science, relationships with its technical institutions, the international support that funds sustainable water, and the judgement to navigate a constrained kingdom safely — rather than the mass mobilisation that other struggles require and that here would be both constrained and risky — an effort's most valuable investments are in building scientific credibility, technical and international relationships, and workable alternatives. A small, well-connected effort that can marshal the state's own water science, engage its technical institutions, offer a real efficiency or reuse alternative, and enlist the donors can accomplish far more, and far more safely, than an attempt at open opposition. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of scientific credibility, technical relationships, and constructive alternatives — all reachable through Jordan's own water institutions and its web of international water partnerships, and all within the grasp of a determined and careful coalition. And because water is the state's paramount concern, the arguments that align with water security, and that offer alternatives rather than mere refusal, are the most persuasive way in.*

WATER-SECURITY ARGUMENT + SCIENCE + STRATEGY + ALTERNATIVES:

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Jordan are **the water-security argument, the science of depletion, the state's strategy, and the alternatives** — used together, within the system. The water-security argument and the science show the ceiling: in the world's most water-scarce country, a project shown to mine or waste water, against the science and the state's own strategy, can genuinely be curbed or improved. The desperate crisis and limited space show the honest floor: the state has real need and few options, and confrontation is constrained. Most Jordanian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to make the water-security case, prove depletion, invoke the state's strategy, and offer alternatives — but that mere refusal fails, the crisis is genuine, and the surest result is that the harm is documented and the wiser use of water advanced.

1. **The water-security argument and the science** — Jordan's distinctive strengths; the self-defeating harm and the undeniable depletion.
2. **The state's own strategy** — the water priorities the state set itself.
3. **The alternatives** — efficiency, reuse, and demand management, without which refusal fails.

4. **The international and donor support** — the water-security apparatus behind sustainable water.
5. **The scientific documentation** — the evidence of depletion and loss that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Water is the state's paramount concern** — so a water-security argument reaches the state where it is most attentive. **The science is undeniable** — the finite fossil aquifer, the dying Dead Sea, the lost wetlands are not in dispute. **The state has its own strategy** — a water-scarce state can be held to its own water priorities. **Alternatives are essential** — mere refusal ignores a real need and fails. **But the crisis is desperate and space is limited** — so the work is careful and within the system. The through-line: **document the water harm; show it threatens the water security the state prizes; press the state's own strategy and the science; offer real alternatives; and work within the system with care — because an effort that does can genuinely protect water and win its wiser use, while being honest that the crisis is desperate, options are few, and there is no easy victory.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the leverage, which here runs through water security and the alternatives. Vague concern goes nowhere, and confrontation is constrained; an effort aimed at "this project mining or wasting this water, threatening the nation's water security, against the state's own strategy and the science, for which this efficiency or reuse alternative exists" is a real, workable effort — the kind Jordan's distinctive levers can deliver. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What water is harmed?** This is the first question here. What **water is mined, wasted, or endangered** — the fossil aquifer drawn down, the wetland pumped dry, the Dead Sea drained, the water squandered.
2. **How does it threaten water security?** How the harm **threatens the water security the state prizes above all** — depleting a finite resource, wasting scarce water, robbing the future.
3. **What does the science and the strategy say?** What the **science of depletion and the state's own water strategy** show about the harm and the sustainable path.
4. **What alternative exists?** What **efficiency, reuse, or demand-management alternative** could serve the need with less harm, since mere refusal fails.
5. **How does the effort work within the system, carefully?** How the effort proceeds through the **water authority, the technical institutions, and civil society**, within the limits of political space, with care.

A Worked Example

Suppose a new well field is planned to mine more of the finite fossil aquifer for a thirsty development, hastening the depletion of an irreplaceable resource, when efficiency and reuse could serve much of the need.

Working the five questions: **what water is harmed? How does it threaten water security? What do the science and strategy say? What alternative exists?** And how does the effort work within the system, carefully? The driver is the state's water need and the development, with the water-security argument, the science, the strategy, and the alternatives as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the state needs water and will mine it" to a real effort: document the depletion; show it threatens the nation's long-term water security; invoke the state's own strategy and the science; offer the efficiency and reuse that could serve much of the need; and work through the water authority and the technical community — all within the system, with care. That is a workable effort suited to Jordan — one that presses the state on its own paramount concern, water. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight within a constrained kingdom: they turn what might seem an impossible target — a desperate state, short of water and pursuing every source it can reach — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that works with the state's own paramount concern rather than against its power. The harm becomes a documentable threat to water security. The threat becomes the state's own foremost worry, turned into an argument. The science becomes the state's own trusted data. The alternative becomes a way to meet the state's genuine need without the irreplaceable loss. And the safety question keeps the effort within the system, where it is both effective and survivable. That translation — from a desperate, seemingly immovable state into a set of specific actions pressed through its own deepest concern — is the first and most important thing a Jordanian effort does, because it moves the fight from open confrontation, where the community is weakest and most exposed, onto the ground of the state's own obsession with water, where it has real and safer purchase.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the science of water, much of it already gathered by the state and its partners. A water ministry, a technical institution, a donor, and the state itself all move on data — and in Jordan, a clear, credible record of the water harm, its threat to water security, and the alternatives is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Water Harm, and the Strategy

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its water driver, and the harm** — the well field and the aquifer it mines, the diversion and the sea it drains, the development and the water it wastes — and, decisively here, **how it threatens water security and what the state's own strategy says**. Much of the water science exists in the state's own institutions and its international partnerships, and is authoritative. Establish exactly **what the project is, what water it harms, and how it threatens the water security the state prizes**, because the harm-to-water-security is the case's foundation.

Layer 2: The Depletion, the Loss, and the Science

Document the harm with the science. Establish the **water harm** — the finite aquifer's depletion, the wetland's loss, the Dead Sea's decline and its sinkholes, the water wasted — drawing on **the state's own water science, the technical institutions, and the international research**, whose data the state trusts. And establish the **long-term threat** — the irreplaceable resource robbed, the future imperilled. The science, the monitoring data, and the visible harm — the dry wetland, the spreading sinkholes — make the depletion undeniable, and the threat to water security makes it the state's own concern.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Water Security, the Alternative, and the System

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **science** prove real depletion or waste? How does it **threaten the water security the state prizes**? What does the state's own **strategy** say, and what **alternative** exists? And how does the effort **work through the system** — the water authority, the

institutions, the donors — carefully? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that presses the state on its own paramount concern with a real alternative in hand. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a scientific harm, a threat to water security, a state strategy invoked, and a real alternative are exactly what let a Jordanian effort press the state where it is most attentive. Build it well, and the water-security argument, the science, the state's strategy, and the alternatives become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: the fact that the water science is largely the state's own is what most distinguishes a Jordanian case and most repays careful attention, because it removes the usual line of retreat available to a project's proponents. In many conflicts, a developer or a state can dispute the opposition's science as biased, alarmist, or amateur, and much energy is spent contesting whose data to believe. In Jordan, the most authoritative data on the aquifers, the Dead Sea, and the nation's water balance comes from the state's own water institutions and its international scientific partnerships, whose science the state funds, trusts, and uses to plan its own survival — so a case built on that science cannot be dismissed as the work of outsiders or opponents without the state impugning its own institutions and its own water planning. Building this layer well therefore means grounding the case, wherever possible, in the state's own hydrological record and its international scientific partnerships, because evidence the state itself produced and relies upon to secure its water future is evidence it cannot easily wave away. That is the distinctive evidentiary strength of a Jordanian effort, and the file should be built to exploit it.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here the decisive evidence is the science of water, much of it already gathered. Here is where the material tends to live in a Jordanian effort, and how to get it — with the **water harm**, the **water-security threat**, the **science**, and the **alternatives** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Water and Strategy Record

Start with the water and the state's strategy, which are the foundation. **The water data, the project plans, the national water strategy, and the water law** establish the harm and the standard; the distinctive strengths here are the **state's own water science** and its **explicit water priorities**, much of it public or reachable through institutional and international channels. Establish the **water harm, its threat to water security, and what the strategy requires**, drawing on the state's own water record. Establish exactly **what water is harmed and against what priority**, because the harm-against-the-state's-own-water-strategy is what the state cannot easily dismiss.

The Depletion and Science Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **depletion evidence** — the fossil aquifer's finite life and falling levels, the wetland's loss, the Dead Sea's decline and sinkholes, the water wasted — and the **long-term threat** to the nation's water future, drawing on **the state's water science, the technical institutions, the monitoring data, and the international research**. This depletion-and-threat evidence is what turns the harm into both a breach of the state's own water priorities and a danger to its future.

The Alternatives and Efficiency Record

Document the alternatives, without which refusal fails. Gather the record of **the efficiency, reuse, and demand-management alternatives** — the agriculture that uses half the water inefficiently, the leakage that loses much of the rest, the treated wastewater and greywater that could serve non-drinking uses, the demand management that could curb waste — that could serve the need with less harm. A community that

can show a real alternative — the water a project would mine or waste, found instead through efficiency and reuse — holds the lever that makes opposition constructive rather than mere refusal.

The International, Transboundary, and Community Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **international water and donor bodies** supporting sustainable water; the **transboundary dimensions** — the fossil aquifer shared with a neighbour, the Dead Sea and river shared across borders — and the cooperation they require; and the **water-stressed communities** who live the scarcity. A community joined to the international partners, mindful of the shared waters, and rooted in the water-stressed people holds levers that reach beyond a single project.

The People, the System, and the Care

Finally, map the human terrain and the careful path. Who is affected — the **water-stressed communities, the farmers, the future generations** — and who can act: the **technical experts, the institutions, the civil society, the international partners**, since political space is limited. And how does the effort **work through the system with care**, given the constraints? A Jordanian effort is advanced largely through the state's own water institutions and science and its international partners, within the limits — so map that coalition deliberately, and let care and a realistic sense of the crisis and the constraints govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in the Jordanian way, because open, adversarial organising is constrained in a kingdom, and the "opposition" that works runs largely through the technical community, the water-stressed communities, and civil society acting within the system, together with the international partners. The task is not to build a confrontational movement, which is limited, but to build a coalition — of experts, affected communities, and civil society — that presses for the wiser use and protection of water through the system.

Why the Within-System Coalition Is Decisive

In Jordan, the coalition that can act is the one that works through the system, because open opposition is constrained. That coalition supplies what an effort runs on: the water experts whose science the state trusts, the affected communities who live the scarcity, the civil society with a voice, and — distinctively — the credibility of pressing the state on its own paramount concern, water security. When experts, communities, and civil society organise to document the harm and press the state's own water priorities, they become a genuine force. **A coalition that works through the state's own water science and priorities here is not a weaker substitute for open protest; it is the form opposition can effectively and safely take in Jordan — the real foundation of an effort, pressing the state on the concern it prizes above all.** This is worth dwelling on, because the instinct imported from more open societies — that real opposition means public confrontation, and that working within the system is a form of capitulation — is not only mistaken in Jordan but counterproductive. In a kingdom with real red lines, open adversarial protest against a state project is both largely ineffective, because the state controls the arenas in which it would occur, and risky for those who attempt it, while achieving little. The within-system path is the opposite: it is where the genuine leverage lies, because the state authentically cares about water security above almost all else, genuinely relies on its own technical institutions and their science, and has genuinely committed itself to a national water strategy — so pressure applied through those channels reaches the state precisely where it is most attentive and most exposed. Recognising this clearly — that the hydrologist documenting an aquifer's decline, the institution invoking the state's own water strategy, and the donor pressing for sustainable water

are not weaker actors than a protester but stronger and safer ones — is the beginning of an effective Jordanian effort, which works with the grain of the state's deepest concern rather than against the wall of its authority.

Finding the Coalition

Begin with those who can act within the system — the **water scientists and engineers, the technical institutions, the water-stressed communities, the environmental groups, and the international partners** — and treat the constraints on open dissent honestly, protecting those involved. Widen to all who share the stake in Jordan's water. Name the shared stake — **our water, our aquifers, our Dead Sea, and the future they hold** — because water is at once the nation's survival, its security, and its children's inheritance. Frame the coalition around water security and the wiser use of a scarce resource, not around confrontation. There is real power in framing the cause this way, because water security is the one concern on which the state, the technical community, the water-stressed public, and the international partners all genuinely converge. Unlike many environmental causes, which can be cast as pitting nature against development or a community against the state, the protection of Jordan's water can be framed as the shared and paramount interest of everyone — the state that fears running dry, the farmer who needs water to farm, the family that queues for it, the scientist who measures its decline, and the donor who funds its future. To frame the coalition around this shared water security, rather than around opposition to the state or a project, is to gather the widest possible circle of support around a concern almost no one in Jordan can dismiss, and to cast the effort not as dissent but as the common defence of the nation's most precious and threatened resource. An effort that names this shared stake well, and couples it always with a constructive alternative, is far harder to marginalise than one framed as confrontation.

Coalition-Building, Within the System

A coalition allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Jordan it runs through the technical world and out to its partners. Reach to the **water scientists and technical institutions; the water-stressed communities and farmers; the environmental and civil-society groups; the international water and donor bodies; and the regional water partners**. Frame the coalition around the water-security argument, the science, the state's strategy, and the alternatives. Build breadth within the system's constraints, favouring the technical, institutional, and international channels over open confrontation, and protecting those involved.

Sustaining the Effort

Jordanian efforts are sustained through the water science and the state's own water priorities. Keep the coalition **informed, connected, and careful**; mark real steps — a study published, an efficiency measure adopted, a depletion slowed, an alternative funded. And keep the effort grounded in water security, the science, and the state's strategy, which are durable and carry credibility within the system. The effort that lasts is the one that works patiently through the system, marshals the science the state trusts, and presses the state to honour its own water priorities. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in the Jordanian case, by the durability and credibility of the scientific record and the technical relationships on which it rests. Unlike a protest movement, which depends on mobilisation and can be dispersed or discouraged, an effort built on accumulating hydrological data and on relationships with the state's own water institutions grows steadily stronger and harder to dismiss over time, because each study adds to an authoritative record the state itself uses to plan its water future, and each relationship deepens the credibility and reach of the effort within the system. This is a slow foundation but a solid one, less vulnerable to the pressures that break open opposition, because it works with the grain of what the state values most. The discipline is to keep building

the science and the technical relationships patiently, so that the effort rests on an ever-growing body of trusted water data and a widening web of credible relationships, which endure and compound in a way that mobilisation alone, in a constrained space, never can.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & WATER-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE WATER STRATEGY, THE SUSTAINABILITY CASE, AND THE ALTERNATIVES

This is where a Jordanian effort is realistically advanced — not through open confrontation, which is constrained, but through the **state's own water strategy, the science of sustainability, and the alternatives**, grounded in credible data. Here the strategy, science, and alternative levers come together, because in Jordan a project that mines or wastes water against the state's own water priorities is pressed through that strategy, that science, and the alternatives.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work within a system the state controls, in a genuine crisis**. The state's water strategy is **real but strained by desperation**; the science is **trusted but must be channelled carefully**; the alternatives are **essential but need resources**; and open challenge is **constrained**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the harm documented, the state's water priorities invoked, a project improved or curbed, and wiser use and alternatives advanced** — real outcomes, if not the halting of a desperate state's water plans. Enter this front clear-eyed: the water strategy, the science, and the alternatives are Jordan's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm to water security is proven and a real alternative is offered** — but the crisis is desperate, options are few, and space is limited.

The Water Strategy and the Sustainability Science

The first and most distinctive front is the state's own strategy and the science. Jordan's **national water strategy and its water priorities** are a real standard the state set itself, and holding the state to its own commitment to sustainable water — pressing against the mining of finite resources, the wasting of scarce water — is a genuine path, because a state whose foremost concern is water security is exposed when a project undermines it. And the **science of sustainability**, gathered by the state's own institutions and international partners, is the foundation: it proves the depletion and the loss authoritatively. Use the science to establish the harm, and the state's own strategy to demand sustainable choices — the two together are the core of a Jordanian effort. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this strategy-and-science front, honestly. Its power is real: a state that has publicly committed itself to water security and sustainable water management, and that presents that commitment as central to its very survival, is genuinely exposed when a project it pursues undermines it, because the gap between its professed water priorities and its conduct is a gap it would rather not display. Its limits are equally real: the same state is acting under genuine desperation, with few good options and a real and pressing need for water, so it may pursue even unsustainable sources not from indifference to its own strategy but because it sees no better immediate choice. Understanding both means using the strategy-and-science lever for what it does best — exposing the gap between the state's sustainable-water commitments and a depleting project, and grounding that in undeniable data — while always pairing it with a genuine alternative that addresses the desperation, because a state shown both that a project betrays its water strategy and that a better way exists to meet its need is far more movable than one merely told that its desperate choice is wrong.

The Alternatives and Demand Management

The second front is the alternative, without which the first fails. Because the state has a real water need, opposition must offer a **better way to meet it**: the **efficiency** in agriculture and networks that could save vast quantities now wasted; the **reuse** of treated wastewater and greywater for non-drinking uses; and the **demand management** that could curb over-use. Build these alternatives with the technical community and the donors, so that the water a project would mine or waste is found instead through efficiency and reuse. This front is what makes opposition constructive and persuasive, because it offers the thirsty state the water it needs without the irreplaceable loss.

The International Support and the Transboundary Dimension

The third front is the support and the shared waters. The **international water and donor bodies** — which fund and shape Jordan's water future — support sustainable choices and can press an aid-dependent state toward efficiency and reuse over depletion. And the **transboundary dimension** — the fossil aquifer shared with a neighbour, the Dead Sea and river shared across borders — calls for cooperation that no single project can substitute. Pursued together — the state's strategy, the sustainability science, the alternatives, the international support, and the transboundary cooperation — these fronts are how a Jordanian effort presses the state on its own paramount concern, water, for the wiser use and protection of a scarce and precious resource, with care for those involved. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Jordan's particular situation. The state's water strategy supplies the standard the state set itself and can be held to. The sustainability science supplies the authoritative, state-trusted evidence that cannot be waved away. The alternatives supply the answer to the state's genuine need, disarming the reply that there is no other choice. The international support supplies scrutiny, resources, and leverage on an aid-dependent state. And the transboundary dimension supplies the recognition that no purely national project can solve a shared-water problem. Each covers the others' limits: the strategy where a standard is needed, the science where proof must be undeniable, the alternatives where the state's need must be met, the support where outside weight helps, and the transboundary frame where the shared nature of the resource must be faced. An effort that grasps this division of labour, and pursues each front through the system with care, makes the fullest use of the several levers that a water-obsessed, water-scarce state uniquely provides — levers that work with the grain of the state's deepest concern, and reach it where it genuinely responds.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same scientific file becomes different arguments for the water authority, the technical institutions, the state, and the international partners. Translate deliberately, and within the system.

For the Water Authority and the State

The water authority responds to **water security and the state's own strategy**. Frame the harm as a threat to the water security the state prizes: here is a project that mines a finite resource or wastes scarce water, against your own strategy and your own foremost concern. Give them the science and the water-security case, and offer the alternative that meets the need with less harm. Make it concrete: *here is the harm to our water security, here is your own strategy, here is a better way*. This is the argument that reaches a state where it is most attentive.

For the Technical and Scientific Institutions

The technical institutions respond to **the science and the sustainability of water**. Frame the harm as a failure of sustainable water management: here is the depletion, the loss, the waste, proven by the data. Give them the science and the alternatives, and enlist their expertise and standing. A technical institution with the science and a mandate for sustainable water is an ally within the system.

For the International and Donor Partners

The partners respond to **sustainable water and sound investment**. Frame the harm as a threat to the water sustainability they fund and value: here is a project that depletes rather than sustains, when efficiency and reuse would serve better. Give them the science, the alternatives, and the water-security case, and press for support of sustainable choices. And handle the regional and transboundary dimensions accurately and evenhandedly. A donor committed to water security is a powerful ally for the sustainable path.

For the Public and the Water-Stressed

The public responds to **their own water and their children's future**. Translate the file into a story anyone who queues for water can grasp: here is the finite water being mined, the wetland lost, the Dead Sea dying, when it could be used more wisely. Frame it as the protection of the nation's water and its future. Keep it accurate; credibility matters in a constrained space. And speak to the shared stake in a scarce and precious resource.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and offer alternatives, not mere refusal. Your credibility is your greatest asset before a water authority and its partners, and it rests on rigorous science and a real alternative; and care for those involved matters in a constrained space. State the harm precisely from the science, tie it accurately to water security and the state's strategy, offer a real alternative, and press within the system. An effort that is precise, constructive, and careful — pressing water security with an alternative in hand — is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or merely refuses, and far safer than one that courts open confrontation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, distinctively, the story is one of a thirsty nation's water being mined and wasted when it could be used more wisely, told through science and with care in a kingdom with real red lines. The story — the finite ancient water pumped away, the dying sea, the sinkholes, the dry wetland — is one that resonates with a people who queue for water.

Why Media Matters

The water authority, the institutions, the state, and the partners behave differently when the harm and the alternative are visible. Media does three things here: it **informs and connects the technical and water-stressed community**, it **raises the stakes** for a state whose foremost concern is water security, and it **connects the harm to the nation's water and future** through credible science. But Jordan is a kingdom with limited media freedom and real red lines, so the media effort runs largely through **technical and scientific channels, the international water and environmental media, and careful public engagement**, rather than confrontational domestic press — and with care for those involved.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with water security and the science. The strongest frame is concrete and resonant: *in one of the world's most water-scarce nations, where families queue for water, an irreplaceable ancient aquifer is being mined, the Dead Sea is dying by a metre a year, a great wetland has been lost, and water is wasted — when efficiency and reuse could serve us far better.* Put the water security and the science first, and the alternative close behind, because the threat to water reaches everyone and the alternative makes the case constructive. Keep it scrupulously accurate; credibility is quickly tested, and overstatement easily dismissed. The Jordanian story is powerful because the water crisis is real and the science is the nation's own. This is the heart of the matter, and it is worth stating plainly why it gives a Jordanian effort its distinctive force. The power of the case lies not in accusation from outside but in the state's own predicament turned into an argument: it is the state itself that has declared water security its paramount concern, the state itself that funds the science measuring the depletion, the state itself that has committed to a sustainable water strategy, and the state itself that then, in desperation, mines the irreplaceable or wastes the scarce. An effort that simply attacked the state would invite its practised defences and endanger those who made it. An effort that instead holds up the state's own water priorities against its own conduct — its own strategy, its own science, its own foremost concern — and offers a genuine alternative to the desperate choice, asks only that the state be true to what it professes and shown a better way, which is a far harder thing for it to refuse and a far safer thing to demand. That is why the state's own obsession with water, and the fact that the evidence for the harm is the state's own, is not merely a rhetorical point but the strategic core of the entire Jordanian approach.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to the constraints. **Technical and scientific publication** for the institutions and the water authority; **international water, environmental, and development media** for the partners and the world; **careful public engagement** on the shared stake in water; and the **regional water conversation** for the transboundary dimensions. Because Jordan's media space is constrained, the technical and international channels matter most — the mining of a thirsty nation's irreplaceable water, documented by its own science, is the story's distinctive power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, careful, and grounded in science — the goal is the wiser use and protection of water, not a story that exaggerates or endangers those involved. Frame the story around water security and the alternatives, and be mindful of the constraints on dissent and the sensitivities of a kingdom, including the security and political red lines. Handle the state, the region, and the transboundary politics — the shared aquifer, the shared sea, the refugees — factually and evenhandedly. And sustain the story through the ongoing science and the water conversation. Above all, let the real crisis — a thirsty nation mining and wasting its irreplaceable water — carry the story, because that is where a Jordanian effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real science, and the real alternative, keep it factual, and work within the system with care. Here the water-security case, and the science, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — water impacts of [project]

To [water authority / ministry],

I am writing on behalf of [community / group] regarding [project] and its effects on [aquifer / wetland / the Dead Sea / water supply]. To understand and respond, we respectfully request the **water-impact assessment**, the **abstraction and monitoring data**, and the **sustainability analysis** for the affected resource. We wish to support the protection of Jordan's water in keeping with the national water strategy.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8B: Submission to the Water Authority

Subject: [Project] and the nation's water security

To the [water authority / ministry],

Scientific data show that [project] would [mine the finite aquifer / waste scarce water / hasten the Dead Sea's decline] in a manner that threatens the water security that is our nation's foremost concern, and appears inconsistent with the national water strategy. We respectfully urge that it be reconsidered in favour of [efficiency / reuse / demand-management] alternatives that serve the need with less harm. We attach the scientific documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8C: Letter to a Technical or Scientific Institution

Subject: Documenting and addressing the water harm of [project]

Dear [institution],

We seek your scientific expertise regarding the water harm of [project] — the [depletion / loss / waste] it would cause. Your data and standing would help establish the harm and support sustainable alternatives, consistent with Jordan's water strategy and its foremost concern for water security. We can share our observations and welcome your assessment and collaboration.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8D: Proposing an Alternative

Subject: Meeting the need through efficiency and reuse, not depletion

To [water authority / ministry / partner],

The need [project] seeks to meet could, in significant part, be met through [efficiency in agriculture and networks / reuse of treated wastewater / demand management], sparing the irreplaceable [aquifer / resource] it would deplete. We respectfully propose these alternatives, which serve our water security without the permanent loss, and we offer to help develop them. We attach the analysis.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8E: Letter to an International or Donor Partner

Subject: Supporting sustainable water over depletion at [location]

Dear [partner / organisation],

We write regarding [project], which would [deplete / waste] scarce water when sustainable alternatives exist. We respectfully request your support for **efficiency, reuse, and sustainable water management** in keeping with the water-security goals you fund, and your engagement with the relevant authorities. We can provide the science and the proposals, mindful of the regional sensitivities.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8F: Media / Scientific Publication Pitch

Subject: A thirsty nation mining its irreplaceable water

Dear [editor / journalist / journal],

In one of the world's most water-scarce nations, an irreplaceable ancient aquifer is being mined, the Dead Sea is dying, and scarce water is wasted — when efficiency and reuse could serve far better. There is a rigorous, resonant water story here, and we can provide the science and the context, told accurately and with care.

Sincerely,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Letter on the Transboundary Dimension

Subject: Cooperation on our shared waters at [location]

To [authority / regional body / partner],

The [shared aquifer / Dead Sea / river] at the heart of [project / concern] is shared across borders, and its protection calls for cooperation that no single project can replace. We respectfully urge that the shared resource be managed sustainably and cooperatively, in the interest of all who depend on it, and we support dialogue toward that end. We attach the relevant science.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8H: Rallying the Coalition

Subject: Our water, our future — let us protect them through the system

Dear colleagues and neighbours,

Our irreplaceable water is being mined and wasted, our Dead Sea is dying, even as we queue for water and our children's future grows uncertain. Together — experts, communities, and civil society — by documenting the harm, showing its threat to our water security, pressing our own water strategy, and offering the efficiency and reuse that could serve us better, we can press for the wiser use and protection of our water,

through the system and with care. Please join us: share the science, engage the institutions, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a harm is acute — a new well field approved, a diversion begun, a mega-project fast-tracked, a wetland going dry — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means the water-security argument, the science, and the technical institutions.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — through the system: **what water is harmed, and how it threatens water security**. Identify the immediate pressure point — a **new well field, a diversion, a fast-tracked project, a drying wetland** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **water scientists, the technical institutions, and the water authority** at once, because in Jordan the trusted science and the water-security argument are the fastest routes to real, and safer, leverage — and begin at once to identify the **alternative**, because refusal without it will not persuade.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The water-security argument** can be made at once, reaching the state where it is most attentive. **The science** can establish the harm quickly and credibly. **The technical institutions** can be engaged fast. **The alternative** can be sketched immediately. These outpace the slower work of building full efficiency programmes and transboundary cooperation — which must follow — because the water-security case and the science can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, frame the harm as a threat to water security with an alternative in hand, because that is the fastest way to reach a thirsty state.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the experts and institutions fast. Reach immediately to the **water scientists, the technical institutions, the water authority, the environmental groups, and the international partners**. A coalition with trusted science, making the water-security case, offering an alternative, is the most a rapid Jordanian effort can do — and the water-security case can bite fast within the system. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the science, and the alternative before the crisis breaks, and work through the system with care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted by a desperate water crisis with few options, by a kingdom's limited political space, by transboundary harm beyond Jordan's sole control, and by the vested interests of powerful water users. This is Jordan's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the crisis is not desperate, or that the state has good options it ignores, or that opposition is free, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The crisis is desperate** — the state mines fossil water and builds costly desalination because it is running out of water. **The options are few** — a water-poor nation has hard choices, not easy ones. **Much harm is transboundary** — the shared aquifer and the dying sea are not Jordan's alone to fix. **Space is limited** — a kingdom with red lines constrains open dissent. **And powerful users resist** — those who benefit from cheap, over-used water resist reform. This is a tilt of scarcity, constraint, and vested interest, and an effort here works it through the water-security argument, the science, the state's strategy, the alternatives, and careful within-system advocacy, not through open confrontation.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers within the system and the state's own concern. Lean on the **water-security argument**, which reaches the state where it is most attentive; the **science**, which is undeniable; the **state's own strategy**, holding it to its water priorities; the **alternatives**, which meet the need and disarm the "we have no choice" reply; and the **international support**, which backs sustainable water. Address the vested interests not by confrontation but by showing that the wider water security they too depend on is threatened, and by pressing the state to enforce its own rules fairly. And build the scientific record and the technical relationships over time, because trusted data and credibility within the system accumulate into real influence. A tilted field here is worked through the state's own concern for water, with care, not against the state or the crisis head-on.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little visible change — the aquifer may still be mined, the sea may still shrink, the project may proceed — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the crisis is desperate and the state's hands are partly tied. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **harm was documented, the water-security threat was shown, the state's strategy was invoked, and an alternative was placed on the table** — and every study published, every efficiency won, every depletion slowed, every alternative funded protects the water that remains. Press for the wiser use of water; even if a project proceeds, the scientific record you built and the alternatives you offered will shape the next decision, because a state whose survival depends on water cannot forever ignore the science of its own depletion.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Jordan, alongside the honest desperation of the water crisis, there is a real problem of water taken unlawfully and rules unenforced against the powerful: illegal wells drilled by influential users, over-abstraction protected by connection, and scarce water captured by the few while ordinary people queue. This must be approached with care in a kingdom with red lines, and the safer, more effective route runs through the water-security argument, the technical institutions, and the international partners.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

In most water-scarce states there is a line between the ordinary tilt of scarcity and the capture of water by the powerful. The marks are specific: **illegal wells and over-abstraction by influential users, rules unenforced against the well-connected, scarce water captured by the few while others go without, and reform blocked by those who benefit from cheap, over-used water**. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish the desperate but lawful management of scarcity from provable, documented illegal abstraction or capture**, and rely on the water-security argument, the science, and the state's own rules, because in a constrained space these are safer and more credible tools than accusation.

Responding to Capture — Through the System, Carefully

Where the unlawful capture of water is real, the response runs through the state's own interest and the technical channels. Use the **water-security argument** to show that unlawful over-abstraction threatens the water security the whole nation, and the state, depend on. Use the **science and monitoring** to document the illegal wells and the over-use. Use the **state's own rules and strategy** to press for fair enforcement, since the state's own water security is undermined by capture. And use the **international partners** to support transparent, sustainable, and fairly enforced water management. Document carefully and protect those involved, because in a constrained space the record must be rigorous and the people shielded. Route the effort through water security, the science, and fair enforcement — not through open confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters throughout. Jordan is a kingdom with real red lines around the monarchy, the security services, and certain political matters, and while environmental and water advocacy is generally more tolerated than overt political dissent, it must still be conducted with care. So favour the **technical, scientific, and institutional channels** over open confrontation; frame the work around water security and the shared interest, not around challenging authority; protect individuals, especially those inside institutions or communities whose positions could be jeopardised; and handle the political, security, and regional matters — including the sensitive transboundary and refugee dimensions — factually and with discretion. Care here is not timidity; it is the recognition that the effective and safe path in Jordan runs through the state's own concern for water, the science, and the alternatives, and that pressing too openly can cost people dearly while achieving less than patient work within the system.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through the system and the state's concern for water. Here is how they fit into a single, careful Jordanian effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, within the system. **Documentation** builds the scientific water file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the within-system coalition, organises the experts, communities, and civil society. **Legal, regulatory, and water-governance** work presses the state's strategy, the science, and the alternatives. **Media**, largely technical and international, carries the water-security case. The water science feeds all five at once — a study is a water-security argument, a strategy case, an alternative, and a story together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, working through a thirsty state's paramount concern, they compound into real influence within the system.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the water harm and the science; identify the water-security threat, the state's strategy, and the alternatives; begin documentation through the technical channels. **Middle (months 2–18):** press the water-security argument and the water authority; engage the technical institutions and the donors; develop and offer the efficiency and reuse alternatives; and build the scientific record. **Later (months and years):** advance sustainable water and demand management, press for fair enforcement, pursue transboundary cooperation, and keep building the science and the relationships whatever the state's course.

A Jordanian effort is patient and works through the system, and its fruits — documentation, efficiency, protection — are gradual; pace it accordingly, and let care govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the water harm; show its threat to the water security the state prizes; press the state's own strategy and the science; offer real alternatives; and work through the system with care.** The coalition that presses all five, working through a thirsty state's own paramount concern, and with care, is the one that can genuinely protect water and win its wiser use — the kind of victory a water-scarce, constrained, but water-obsessed state allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project in Jordan is genuinely difficult, and bound up with an existential water crisis that leaves the state few good options, with a kingdom's limited political space, and with harm that reaches across borders, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the crisis is desperate, the options are few, much harm is transboundary, and there is no easy victory. And yet the effort is far from futile, because water is Jordan's binding constraint and its foremost concern, so a project that mines, wastes, or gambles with water is self-defeating on the state's own terms, its own science documents the depletion undeniably, its own strategy commits it to sustainable water, and real alternatives of efficiency and reuse exist — and those levers of the water-security argument, the state's strategy, the science, and the alternatives are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **Water is the state's paramount concern — so a water-security argument reaches it where it is most attentive. The science of depletion is undeniable and largely the state's own. The state's own strategy commits it to sustainable water. But the crisis is desperate, options are few, and alternatives, not mere refusal, are essential.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive, within-system levers grounded in the state's own concern for water, and the honest weight of a desperate crisis and a constrained space.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the care — that give these efforts their force. Document the water harm. Show its threat to the water security the state prizes. Press the state's own strategy and the science. Offer real alternatives. And work through the system with care — because in a water-scarce kingdom whose survival turns on water, an effort that presses the state on its own deepest concern, with the science in hand and an alternative to offer, through the system and with care, is the one that is both effective and just.

Jordan is one of the driest nations on earth, a small kingdom where families queue for water a few hours a week, and where the gravest harms are done not by belching industry but by the mining of an irreplaceable ancient aquifer, the draining of a dying sea now pocked with sinkholes, the loss of a great wetland, and the wasting of water a thirsty nation cannot spare; this guide has hidden none of it, nor pretended that a state running out of water has easy choices, or that much of the harm is not beyond its borders, or that a kingdom's political space is open, and there is no landmark victory here to promise you. But the very thing that makes Jordan's predicament so grave is also the lever: because water is the nation's binding constraint and its foremost concern, a project that mines or wastes it is undermining the very security the state prizes above all, and can be pressed — on the state's own terms, with the state's own science, against the state's own strategy, and with a better way in hand. There is no easy victory, and no escaping the desperation of the crisis; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on care for those who act. But the water of Jordan is worth protecting, the levers that run through a thirsty state's own deepest concern are real, and the patient, careful work of documenting the harm, making the water-security case, and offering the wiser use of

a precious resource is one a community can genuinely do — from within the system, and press for the protection of Jordan's water. So can you.